Misinformation: Automating truth in the era of fake news

"Misinformation" has become associated with a new scientific paradigm that studies people making, reading, and sharing false statements, usually on social media. Misinformation reconceptualizes the role of scholarship into its inverse: Rather than producing knowledge, misinformation research monitors a stream of public content for false knowledge. Teaching is replaced with regulation, and education, like public health, must engage in disease-surveillance, lest the infodemic spread unchecked, endangering democracy. Knowledge might be sought, curated, shared, or cultivated, but democracy must defend against misinformation, or its more sinister (and probably foreign) cousin, disinformation.

Misinformation focuses on the content, sources, and consumers of misinformation, not its context, cultural form, or structural factors. Misinformation research emphasizes the directness of interactions on social media, oblivious to the medium, interrogating (or policing) users by analyzing the content and connections they make. There is rarely mention of the legions of designers, engineers, product managers, etc. that design and actively maintain social media to work the way it does, or the reasons that they do so. When misinformation research does consider social media companies as more than passive conduits for pseudo-direct interactions, they are assumed to be potential collaborators in defending against misinformation by, for example, deploying tools to detect it, a common proposal in the literature.

Above all, misinformation is a concept that undermines its advocates' putative goals. Misinformation attempts to understand how the public can be deceived while ignoring the actual practices of those who do public relations, marketing, and military propaganda, who operate in the chasm between true and false, rather than at its poles. Misinformation therefore focuses inquiry on the least salient part of the relevant phenomenon. Among both the public and scholars, it reenforces a narrow misconception that propaganda is made of lies, and, by extension, implies that there is an alternative political discourse available based on simple facts. At best, it fosters an inadequate critical literacy; at worst, it functions as misdirection for an epistemic sleight of hand, under whose cover questions of truth are swapped for those of power. In aligning itself with governments and social media companies, misinformation scholarship seeks to defend democracy from the top down, an antiparticipatory approach that undermines its public credibility but aligns the interests of science with those of corporations and states, just as the scientific community attempts to ward off the real and dangerous challenges to its privileged position in society.